

Chapter 9

You Will Know Soon

It was late evening when Elara finally came downstairs.

Dinner had already been prepared.

Her mother was sitting at the table while her father was going through a thick folder beside his plate.

Elara pulled out a chair.

"What are you reading?"

Her father closed the folder.

"Something important."

She looked at him.

"Work?"

"Yes."

He rested one hand on the folder.

"We received an investment proposal today."

Elara reached for her glass.

"From whom?"

"Veyron Holdings."

The name immediately caught her attention.

She had heard it before.

It was one of the investment companies people had been talking about recently.

"Veyron?"

Her father nodded.

"They want to make a major investment in one of our upcoming projects."

"That's good."

"It is."

He paused.

"Very good, actually."

Elara looked at him.

"Who owns it?"

Her father was quiet for a moment.

Then he answered.

"Roman Ashford."

Her fingers stopped moving.

For a second...

she didn't hear anything else.

Her heart suddenly began beating faster.

Roman.

After three years...

his name was suddenly sitting at the same dinner table as her.

She pressed her right hand against her other hand beneath the table, trying to steady herself.

Her father noticed her expression.

"You know him."

It wasn't a question.

Elara looked down.

"Yes."

"From college?"

She nodded.

Her father opened the folder again.

"Veyron wasn't originally Roman's company. It was already an established business, but it was struggling badly when he entered."

Elara remained silent.

"He bought a controlling stake," her father continued. "Changed the management. Sold several weak assets. Restructured their investments."

He turned another page.

"And in three years..."

He paused.

"The company became something completely different."

Elara looked at the papers.

"How big is it now?"

Her father gave a small smile.

"Big enough that companies like ours have to take its decisions seriously."

She didn't answer.

Her thoughts had already gone somewhere else.

The abandoned library.

That dark room.

The hand over her mouth.

The fragrance.

The voice.

You shouldn't have come here.

Could it really have been him?

But now...

Roman was coming back into the picture.

Her father continued.

"There's a meeting tomorrow."

Elara looked up.

"With Veyron?"

"Yes."

She swallowed.

"Is Roman coming?"

"I assume so."

Her father closed the folder.

"Try not to let personal history affect business."

Elara forced a small smile.

"I won't."

Her mother looked at her plate.

"You haven't touched your food."

"I'm not hungry."

"You should eat something."

"I'm just tired."

She stood.

"I'll go upstairs."

Her father nodded.

"Get some rest. Tomorrow will be important."

Elara turned away.

She didn't say anything else.

She closed her bedroom door behind her.

The room was dark.

She didn't turn on the lights.

For a few seconds, she simply stood there.

Roman Ashford.

Veyron Holdings.

Tomorrow's meeting.

And that man in the library.

Her mind kept trying to connect things she wasn't ready to connect.

She walked to her bed and sat down.

Her phone lay beside her.

She picked it up.

The unknown number was still there.

She had received the number recently, but had never known who was behind it.

She opened the conversation.

The screen was empty.

Her thumb hovered over the keyboard.

She typed:

Was that you in the library that night?

She stared at it.

Then deleted it.

She tried again.

Were you the one who was there that night?

Delete.

She sighed.

"Why is this so difficult?"

She looked at the screen again.

Her fingers moved slowly.

This time, she typed:

Was it you that night?

She read it once.

Then again.

Her heart was beating faster.

She almost deleted it.

But this time...

she pressed send.

The message appeared on the screen.

Sent.

Elara immediately placed the phone beside her.

She stood up.
Took two steps.
Stopped.
Turned around.
Picked the phone up again.
Nothing.
She waited.
A minute passed.
Then another.
Still nothing.
She put the phone down.

Across the city...
Roman sat alone in his apartment.
The lights were dim.
Rain tapped quietly against the large windows.
A file from Veyron lay open on the coffee table.
But Roman wasn't reading it anymore.
His phone vibrated.
He looked down.
An unfamiliar number.
A message.
He opened it.

Was it you that night?

Roman stared at the screen.
For several seconds...
he didn't move.
He already knew who was behind the message.
He leaned back against the sofa.
His eyes moved toward the window.
The city lights blurred slightly behind the rain.
A memory returned.
An abandoned library.
A frightened girl.

His hand over her mouth.
A voice whispering for silence.
His eyes lowered to the phone again.
He could answer.
He could tell her the truth.
But not yet.
His thumb moved across the screen.
He typed:
You will know soon.
He read the words once.
Then pressed send.
Roman placed the phone on the table.
He remained silent for a moment.
Then he leaned back and closed his eyes.
Tomorrow...
he would see her again.
Not from a distance.
Not through an old photograph.
In person.

Elara's phone lit up.
She picked it up immediately.
Her eyes moved across the screen.
You will know soon.
She frowned.
She read it again.
And again.
"What does that even mean?"
She stared at the message.
"Ahhhh..."
She dropped the phone onto the bed and ran a hand through her hair.
"Why can't he just answer a simple question?"
She picked the phone up again.
The same four words remained on the screen.

You will know soon.

She didn't know whether the reply had made her more curious...

or more nervous.

Tomorrow's meeting suddenly felt much closer than it had a few minutes ago.

Elara turned off her phone.

But sleep didn't come easily.

Because somewhere across the city...

Roman was awake too.

And after three years...

neither of them could pretend that the past was still buried.

The Next Morning

The alarm rang at seven.

Elara opened her eyes before it could ring a second time.

For a moment, she stared at the ceiling.

Then she remembered.

The meeting.

She reached for her phone.

The last message was still there.

You will know soon.

She stared at it for another second before locking the screen.

"Okay."

She got ready quietly.

Dark blazer.

Simple shirt.

Her hair tied back neatly.

Nothing about her appearance suggested how restless she felt inside.

Downstairs, breakfast was already waiting.

Her father looked up when she entered.

"Morning."

"Good morning."

"You ready?"

Elara picked up her coffee.

"As ready as I'll ever be."

He smiled.

"Good. Veyron's team is arriving at ten."

She nodded.

She didn't ask who would be leading the meeting.

She already knew.

At Northbridge Group, the conference room had been prepared since early morning.

Documents were arranged across the table.

Screens were on.

Assistants moved quietly in and out.

Elara stood near the windows for a moment, looking down at the city.

Her father's voice came from behind her.

"They're here."

She turned.

The conference room door opened.

Several people entered first.

Executives.

Advisors.

Assistants.

Then...

Roman walked in.

Elara's breath caught.

For one second...

everything around her seemed to disappear.

He looked different.

Stronger.

More composed.

There was something controlled about the way he carried himself now.

His eyes moved across the room.

Then stopped on her.

Neither of them spoke.

Roman's expression barely changed.

But his gaze stayed on her for one moment longer than it should have.

Then he turned toward the table.

"Good morning."

Elara couldn't answer immediately.

Because before she could even think...

a familiar fragrance reached her.

Her heart dropped.

The library.

The darkness.

The hand over her mouth.

That voice.

Everything came back at once.

She looked at him again.

This time...

there was no doubt.

It had been him.

The unknown man.

The one who had pulled her into the darkness.

The one who had told her to stay away.

Roman.